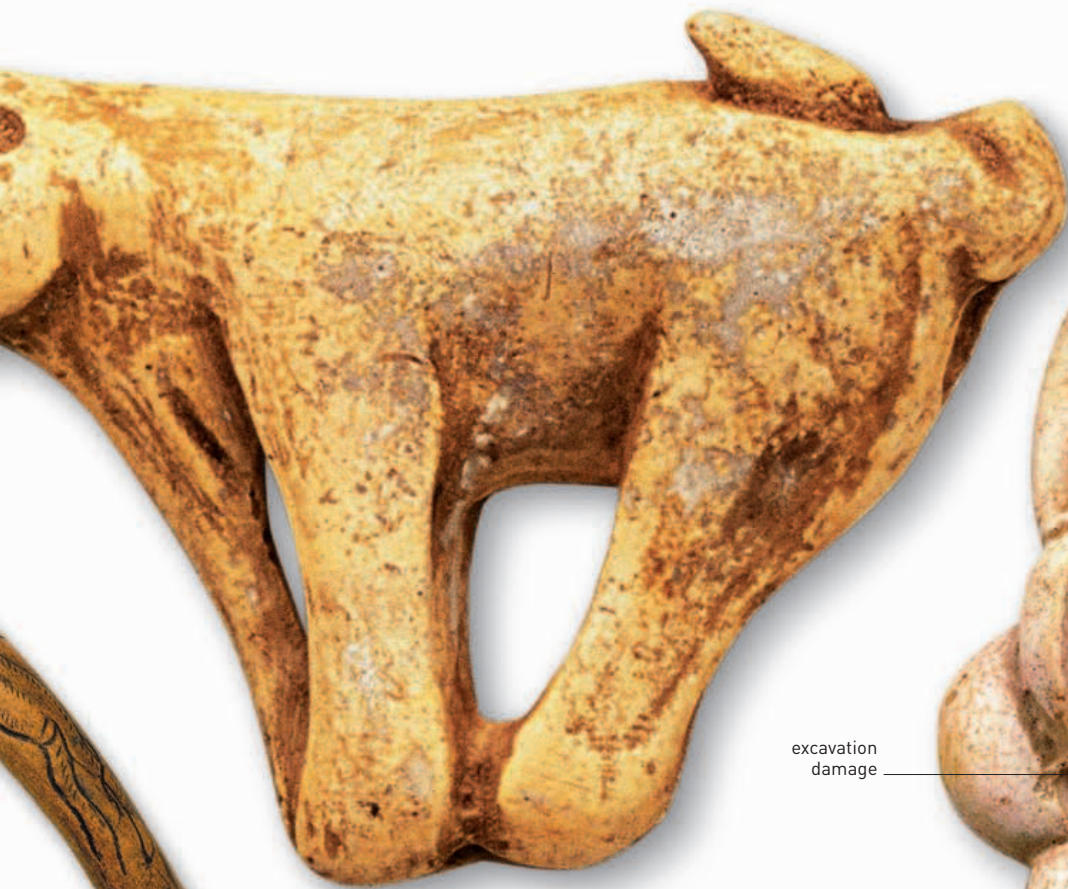




Carved spear-thrower
10,500BCE • FRANCE
Spear-throwers, such as this one from Montastruc, were often carved into animal shapes—here, a woolly mammoth made from antler. They enabled hunters to throw spears farther and with greater force.

excavation damage



exaggerated features



Clay burial chest
4000BCE • NEAR EAST
One Chalcolithic ("copper age") burial practice involved leaving the dead out to decay, then collecting the bones and placing them in clay chests like this one.



Mummified head
7000–3000BCE • PERU
In very dry climates, bodies can become mummified. Some of the earliest mummies have been found in Peruvian deserts.



Neolithic flint blade set in reproduction handle

Lespugue Venus
24,000–22,000BCE • FRANCE
This ivory figurine from Lespugue in the Pyrenees is one of many "Venus" figurines—depicting women who are pregnant or obese, or whose female features are greatly exaggerated.



Bronze Age sickle

Gold jewelry
4700–4200BCE • BULGARIA
At the cemetery of Varna in Bulgaria, more than 3,000 pieces of some of the earliest gold jewelry have been found, mainly buried with elite males.



gold easily worked into decorative animal shapes



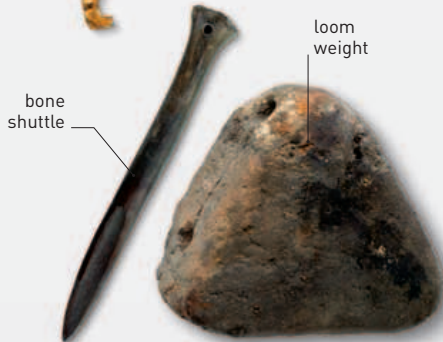
iron sickle blade

Agricultural tools
9500BCE–1834CE • WIDESPREAD
First wild and later domesticated cereals were harvested using sickles like these, until they were superseded in most places by the invention of the combine harvester.



soft clay was baked to preserve design

Neolithic seal
7500–5700BCE • ANATOLIA
Seals such as this one from the settlement of Çatal Höyük were used during the Neolithic to stamp decorative designs on to skin or cloth.



bone shuttle

loom weight

Cloth-making tools
6500BCE • ORIGIN UNKNOWN
From the mid-Neolithic, weaving became common. Loom weights held vertical threads taut; bone shuttles were used to weave horizontal threads in and out.